

To the Editor-in-Chief,
IEEE Transactions on Biometrics, Behavior, and Identity Science

Manuscript: Cross-Age Face Verification from Mined Same-Person Social-Media Pairs: A Naturally-Supervised Longitudinal Signal

Type: Regular paper

Dear Editor,

We submit the manuscript above for consideration as a regular paper. Below we disclose, proactively, the three points on which this submission departs from the journal’s default expectations.

1. The dataset is not released to the general research community, and why. T-BIOM’s Information for Authors states that where the main results rest on a dataset that is not available to the community, this must be explained and justified. Our results rest on face images mined from public social-media “then/now” posts. We do *not* redistribute them, for reasons we consider dispositive rather than convenient:

- The data are biometric. Under Russia’s 152-FZ (as amended by 519-FZ, 2020) public posting does not constitute authorization for dissemination, and Art. 11 requires written consent for biometric data used to identify a person. Under the GDPR a face processed for unique identification is special-category data (Art. 9), and the “manifestly made public” exception is read narrowly. We hold no written consent, and the subjects cannot feasibly be contacted.
- Redistributing such a corpus would create exactly the artifact the paper argues against: a public, non-consensual biometric database of identifiable individuals across decades of their lives.

What we do release instead, so the work remains verifiable and reusable: the complete mining, curation, training and evaluation code; all configurations and random seeds; the de-identified benchmark protocol (pair lists by salted identifier, with age gaps and split assignment, containing no images and no recoverable identities); a datasheet for the dataset; and all reported metrics as machine-readable files. Every number in the manuscript is reproducible from these artifacts given re-collection under the reader’s own legal basis, and the external results (LFW, AgeDB-30, CALFW, FG-NET) are reproducible outright, since those datasets are public. Reconstruction from a public source is additionally demonstrated in the paper by an independent non-VK replication (Reddit).

2. Human subjects and ethical review. The study analyses images that their subjects had already published on public community walls, retrieved through the platform’s official API. There is no interaction or intervention with any person, no individual is identified or contacted, no system is deployed, minors are excluded as subjects, and the released artifacts contain no raw faces, no raw posts and no recoverable identifiers. On that basis the study was not submitted for prospective institutional review, and the manuscript states this affirmatively together with the reasoning — which IEEE policy accepts in place of an approval reference (“...or include an explanation as to why such a review was not conducted”). We do not resolve the counter-consideration in our own favour: the images are biometric and the individuals remain identifiable, which is why our release policy is restrictive rather than open, and why we have *also* requested a formal determination from our university’s ethics committee. We will forward that determination, together with its filing date, to the editor as soon as it is issued; we omit a date here so that nothing in the record can drift from the document itself. We will abide by that determination to the editor as soon as it is issued, and we will abide by it rather than by our own reading.

Consent: the subjects cannot feasibly be contacted, so individual consent for participation and for publication was not obtained; the manuscript explains this, as IEEE policy likewise permits (“...or explain why consent was not obtained”).

3. Originality and prior submissions. The manuscript is original, is not published elsewhere, and is not under review at any other venue. It is not an extension of a published conference paper, so the 30% new-material rule for conference extensions does not apply. An earlier version was submitted to, and rejected by, another IEEE journal; that manuscript was never published, and the present version differs substantially: the evaluation of the LFW forgetting control was found to be defective and has been corrected (the previously reported accuracy cost and low-FAR degradation were artifacts of an unaligned evaluation path and do not survive correction), and a new analysis shows that the standard random-impostor protocol understates the task – with look-alike impostors, frozen state-of-the-art recognizers fall below chance on the 25-year-gap subset.

We confirm that all authors have approved the submission and the author list, and that the figures, tables and reported results accurately reflect the experimental work. The authors declare no conflict of interest.

Sincerely,
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